



# FOUNDATIONS

Why Structure Is Everything

William Christopher Anderson

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# Dedication

*For Fox, Benjamin, and Chloe —  
who made everything I built worth building,  
and who will one day understand that the structure a person  
creates  
is never really about the code.*

*And for Sarah.*

*You have been present for the years that are in this book  
and the years that are not.  
You have seen the work and the cost of it.  
You have held things together when I was not capable of holding  
them myself,  
and you have done it without asking me to be grateful,*

*which made me more grateful than I knew how to say.*

*The chapters in here about family and faith and what survives —  
they exist because of what you gave.*

*More than any reasonable person should have had to give.*

*I do not know what shape our life takes after this.*

*What I know is that you are the love of my life.*

*That was true before I understood it.*

*It will be true in whatever future either of us inhabits.*

*If I lose you, it will be my life's great loss —  
not because of what we built together,  
but because of what you are.*

*This book is yours.*

*It was always yours.*

*Whatever comes.*

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## Preface: What This Book Is

*The test of a first-rate intelligence is the ability to hold two opposed ideas in the mind at the same time, and still retain the ability to function.*

(F. Scott Fitzgerald, *The Crack-Up*)

There is a question at the center of software architecture that I spent twenty years learning to ask precisely: how do you build something that survives change?

The naive answer is build it right the first time. That answer is wrong. Systems do not fail because they were designed badly at the start. They fail because change accumulates faster than the architecture can absorb it. The requirements shift, the business changes direction, the team turns over, the technology evolves, and the structure that was perfectly adequate for what you knew when you built



it is suddenly fighting everything you learned after. The question is not how to design correctly. It is how to design in a way that can survive being wrong.

I have spent the same twenty years applying that question to my own life without knowing I was doing it.

This book is two things simultaneously. It is a rigorous software engineering framework (Harmonic Design) built from twenty years of practice across some of the largest systems in commercial technology. And it is the biography of the life that produced it: a childhood of roughly thirty moves between my parents' separate collapses, a library that was always open when everything else was not, text-based worlds I built on a public terminal before I understood what programming was, a son I was raising at twenty-one with no instruction manual, and a marriage I almost lost and may yet: a framework finished in a motel room in April 2026 while all of that was still in motion.

Neither piece is decorative. The biography is not a warm-up for the framework. The framework is not the payoff for the biography. They are two readings of the same thing.

The organizing principle of the framework (design around what changes, not around what currently is) turns out to be the organizing principle of a life too. That is not a metaphor. It is the argument.

This is not a memoir that uses software as a clever device. The technical content is real and rigorous; the whitepapers behind it have been applied at scale, and engineers who read it should find it useful. It is also not a framework book that uses biography as color. The biographical content is honest, including the parts that are

not easy to tell, because the framework cannot be fully understood without the conditions that produced the questions it answers.

Some of what you will find here is ugly. Addiction. Violence. A single incident of abuse at fourteen that my mother failed to address, and that I am still measuring the cost of. A manic episode in which I gave away \$75,000 and threatened to kill myself. A marriage being rebuilt in real time as I write this, with the outcome not yet settled. None of it is included for shock. All of it is load-bearing. Remove it and the framework floats: technically coherent but unanchored, interesting on the page and inert in practice.

The book is organized in eight parts. Each contains both the biographical arc and the framework element it surfaces. I have not arranged the biography to flatter the framework, or shaped the framework to resolve the biography cleanly. The seams show in places. I think that is correct. Clean seams, in architecture and in life, often mean you have concealed rather than resolved.

One more thing before the story starts.

I grew up knowing that structure was not guaranteed. My father taught me to ask good questions; he also attempted suicide with a butcher knife in our kitchen when I was six. My mother loved me; she also failed me in the specific and concrete way that a parent can fail a child. The library was always open, and it was sometimes the only stable thing I had. I left home at fifteen. I have been building structure (in code, in organizations, in rooms where people are trying to make something that lasts) ever since.

The framework in this book is called Harmonic Design. A vibrating string produces not one frequency but many: a fundamental tone and a series of harmonics above it that do not contradict the fundamental but arise from the same underlying physics. That is what I set out to build: an approach to software where the architecture, the experience design, the testing strategy, and the project plan all arise from the same underlying principle, each one reinforcing the others, nothing fighting anything else.

I wanted the same thing for my life. I am still working on it.

This is where I am. This is what I know. Here is what it cost to find it out.

## **Part I: Before the Framework**

# Chapter 1: Thirty Moves

1985–2003

✦ ✦ ✦

*Home is where one starts from.*

(T.S. Eliot, “East Coker”)

Every day when I was four or five years old, in the yard of our house in Cedarville, I let a turtle go.

I’d carry it around for a while (small, muddy, already pulling its head in) and then set it loose near the edge of the grass. That evening, when Dad came home from work, he’d hold out a turtle for me to take. A new one, I thought. I’d take it like it was treasure.

I didn't find out until years later that it was the same turtle. He was catching it every night after I let it go, bringing it back when he came home because he knew how much I loved it. He kept the ruse going for months, maybe longer. The patience of it, the consistency, the care about what it cost me not to notice: that was my father before everything else. The man who thought through the details of small kindnesses and executed them without being found out.

He'd let me sleep between him and Mom when we had no money for a room of my own. At bedtime, he'd answer every question I had: unlimited, for as long as I could think of them. Then, when he finally got tired, he'd tell me I had twenty questions left, and I'd lie there in the dark thinking carefully about which twenty were worth spending.

Sometimes, while I was thinking, I'd just fall asleep, as happy as I've ever been.

I believed he was the smartest, coolest man alive. I wasn't entirely wrong. I just didn't know yet what he was also capable of.



I was born July 5th, 1985, in Paris, Arkansas: a small town in Logan County that most people have never heard of and that I left before I was old enough to remember it clearly. My earliest real memories are from a few years later: a yellow learning game shaped like an elephant, the trunk curling along its edge, that taught me letters and numbers. I was reading by three or four. I'd read the backs of cereal boxes out loud to my sisters and they'd cheer, and I'd do it

again. That dynamic (my capability stepping into someone else's need) became a pattern that ran through everything afterward, and was, in time, a burden as much as a gift.

There were five of us. Nikki was four years older. Jessie was three years older. I was the only boy. Savanna would come years later, half-sister, born to a different father during the wreckage of what followed. But in the early years it was the five of us: Mom and Dad, two daughters, one son, trying to hold a household together with insufficient money and insufficient tools and a growing problem with alcohol and drugs that neither of them was equipped to address.

Before this story goes where it goes: I love them, all of them, deeply, in ways I have never fully known how to say. I did not and do not have the relationships I wanted with any of them. Both of those things live in me at the same time, and they do not cancel each other out. The love was not a consolation prize for the missing relationship. It was its own real thing, and it is still there.

We passed through Cedarville briefly (long enough for me to remember a screened-in porch where you could sit and listen to rain without getting wet), but Van Buren was where we landed, where I grew up, where everything that matters in this chapter happened. Fort Smith, just across the river, was where I eventually found the pool hall and something like independence.

But before all of it: Mom singing to us (not well, but without a trace of self-consciousness about it), taking us places, present in a way that children file away without knowing they're filing it.

I'm telling you this now, before the rest of it, because what follows tends to crowd out what came before. Don't let it. The porch and the singing and the warmth: those happened. The collapse happened too. Both things were true about my family, and the difficulty of holding them together at the same time is something I have spent forty years working out.



By age five we were living at Flat Rock Court, a trailer park in Van Buren. Mom and Dad were both drinking hard by then, and Dad was already experienced with meth: recreational at that point, but experienced. They smoked prodigious amounts of pot too, though I understand well enough how marijuana can take the edge off a hard situation, and I'll leave it at that.

The fights were getting worse: two people under that kind of pressure with nowhere to go, grinding each other down.

One night they got into it and Dad smashed Mom's face through a glass coffee table. I heard the sound of it shattering. She staggered to her knees, wobbly, and I saw her face; I still remember her tooth jutting out of her bottom lip, the blood, the way she looked like something had gone wrong with the world at a structural level. Then Aunt Amy came through the door screaming: *"You killed my sister, you son of a bitch."* That's when I ran. I hid under a neighbor's porch and stayed there for hours, not knowing what to do, not yet capable of understanding what I was waiting for.

He hadn't killed her. But he had killed something between them.



After that we moved. The new place was an actual house: green, with a front and back yard so overgrown the bushes reached higher than the windows. Dad and Melvin spent a week trimming them down together, clearing the yard, getting it livable. It was halfway condemned, probably, but it wasn't on cinder blocks, and after Flat Rock Court that felt like something. We moved in and it felt like a fresh start.

We called it the hell house for the rest of our lives. But moving in, it didn't feel like that yet.

That came later. Melvin stayed. He was Dad's friend, which is the detail that makes everything else worse. He came from a family where the father made the boys fight each other for sport. Most of them ended up convicted of something. Most of them ended up addicted to something. He and Mom started an affair under the same roof where Dad was still trying to hold a marriage together, with his friend sleeping down the hall.

The fights were no longer about pressure. They were about the reason for the pressure standing right there in the room.

\* \* \*

The divorce happened when I was in first grade: JJ Izzard Elementary, Van Buren. I came home to find Nikki and Jessie sitting on the porch swing at the hell house, crying. I walked over and sat down and started crying too, and I didn't yet know why. Inside, Mom and Dad were screaming. Aunt Amy was there, also screaming. At some point Mom and Amy rushed out with my sisters, but I stayed with Dad.

I watched him fall apart. Then he pulled a butcher knife from the block and began carving into his chest, saying that Mom was his heart and he was going to finish what her leaving had started. I was terrified in the specific bodily way that a six-year-old is terrified; it was in my hands and my stomach, not just my understanding. I told him: if you kill yourself, I'm going to kill myself too. He said that if I killed myself, he'd come back and kill me. The logic was recursive and made no sense. It worked anyway.

I stopped, and, more importantly, so did he.

We sat there and waited for Grandma Lucas to come from Kansas and take him. While we waited I cried with him and sometimes went out to the tire swing he'd hung in the front yard. When Grandma Lucas arrived, Mom had returned, and I had to choose which parent to go with. I started toward Dad. He told me to stay with my mother and be the man of the house.

I took that seriously, and I have been trying to be that man ever since.



That same year (just after Christmas, still six years old) Mom and Dad attempted a reconciliation. They moved into Jesse Turner Terrace, low-income housing just up the hill from the hell house, and for a while, I don't know how long, things felt like they might hold. Time is unreliable in childhood, especially in childhood like mine. All five of us in the same space, the fighting stopped, the house quiet in the evenings. That is my last clear memory of genuine family happiness. I used to think that period must have

been longer than it actually was. People tend to expand the good periods in memory and compress the bad ones. I think I do the opposite.

Then Mom discovered she was pregnant with Melvin's child.

She left again (Nikki chased her down the road begging, and she went anyway), and she would stay married to Melvin for over twenty years.

The day after (or maybe a few days later, the timing is uncertain) I came home from school, King Elementary by then, expecting to watch cartoons with Dad the way we always did: *Animaniacs*, *Tiny Toons*, *Pinky and the Brain*, the whole afternoon block. He was asleep and wouldn't wake up. I called 911. They took him away and pumped his stomach. He had overdosed intentionally.

That was not the last time. When I was eight or nine he took a Ginsu knife to his wrist after a fight with his second wife, Anne, and nearly bled out. I wasn't there; I only got to visit him in the hospital after. I remember sitting with him and asking: "*Daddy, why do you hurt yourself?*" Having gazed long enough at my own shortcomings, I understand that why all too well. The surgeries that followed restored most, but not all, of the function in his hand.

♦ ♦ ♦

Before the divorce, my parents moved plenty; I can count about six distinct houses, trailers, and apartments across those early years. Still too frequent for a child to feel settled, but nothing that would prepare you for what came next.

The real chaos started when Mom and Melvin made it permanent: that's when the thirty moves happened. Not because my parents couldn't decide where to put me. Because we were always being put out. Money would run out. A landlord would reach the end of his patience. A neighbor would file a complaint, or the wrong person would get into the wrong argument with the wrong person, or Mom or Melvin would just get itchy feet and decide that somewhere else had to be better than here. There was always a reason. Sometimes I wouldn't even bother pulling things out of boxes: just leave them in there, because boxes were easier to move when the time came, and the time always came.

Between ages six and fifteen I moved over thirty times. Not between two houses: to thirty different addresses. Houses, trailers, and apartments. Whoever would take us.

New landlords, new neighborhoods, new school districts, new kids who didn't know me and old kids I had to leave behind. No bedroom that was mine for more than a few months. No wall I could put a nail in without wondering if I'd have to patch it before we left. Sometimes we stayed with a relative for a stretch. Sometimes it was just wherever someone would take us.

We never stopped long enough for any of it to feel permanent, which meant we never stopped long enough for me to believe that permanent was a thing that existed.

What held was the library. In the early years it was the school library: whatever school I happened to be in, there was always a library, and it was always the same kind of place. Around twelve, I found the public library, and that was something else entirely. Free. Always open. No

questions asked, no adult required to bring you or come back for you. A computer available every day. You could walk in with nothing and leave knowing something.

That was a kind of structural guarantee I hadn't found anywhere else, and I understood it without being able to say what I understood.

I read everything I could reach. At home (whatever home it currently was) we had a few volumes of Encyclopaedia Britannica. The "A" volume introduced me to Atlantis and I spent a year obsessed with lost civilizations. Greek mythology. Huckleberry Finn. The Bible. Whatever was on the shelf or the floor or the windowsill. Those nights with Dad had done their work: I thought of reading as thinking, and I thought of thinking as the thing that differentiated people who could handle whatever came from people who couldn't. I was building something out of that belief. I just didn't have a name for it yet.

\* \* \*

Around second grade we were in Kibler: a small rural town between Van Buren and Alma. A horse kicked me in the head in a field near the trailer. A neighbor watching from his kitchen window saw a small body arc through the air and brought me to Mom, telling her the boy might be dead. My only real memory from my entire second-grade year is waking up on the porch, spitting out teeth, and saying: *"Mama, that damn horse kicked out my teeth"*, and then going dark.

I had nearly overcome a speech impediment through speech therapy in kindergarten and first grade. The kick regressed it completely. I carried it until I was twenty-five, when I could finally afford my own insurance and private therapy. Every school move reset the clock on accessing services: by the time a new district's therapist found me in the roster, we'd moved again.

Also in Kibler: I ate part of an elephant ear plant. The calcium oxalate crystals caused my tongue to swell badly enough to partially obstruct my airway. Both of these incidents were survivable. Both pointed to the same condition: a child who was not being watched.

Mom was still present during this period, but the woman I remembered from Cedarville was beginning her long drift. Meth and pills were pulling her incrementally further. She would find her way back, but not until I was in my thirties, and that story belongs later in this book.



The best two years of my childhood were the years I got to live with my childhood best friend Josh.

Josh Broadway was my best friend first: that's the part that mattered. His mother was Debbie Newman, and it was through me and Josh that Dad eventually met her. Josh was kind and steady, a little bit rigid: the kind I've come to recognize, looking back and knowing him now, as neurodivergent. He'd tell you himself.

I loved Debbie like a second mother. She took me in without ceremony, fed me, kept the lights on, and never once made me feel like a problem she hadn't planned for. But she wasn't soft about it either. She knew I was bright,

she told me so, and then she told me that bright didn't mean anything if I wasn't willing to work for it. She held me accountable in a way almost no adult in my life had. That meant something. It still does.

It was the most stable stretch I'd had: one address for two consecutive years, reliably there in the mornings. Not without chaos (nowhere in my life was without chaos), but the boxes stayed put, and after everything that had come before, that was its own kind of luxury.

I was drinking by twelve. Nothing catastrophic yet, nothing I couldn't account for. Dumb pranks, running with friends, once tipping over a buffalo sculpture at school. The energy of a kid with too much intelligence and nowhere to put it, who had learned early that the only reliable way to get what he needed was to take it. I was mostly happy during those years. I want to say that plainly, because mostly happy was not a thing I could say about most of my childhood.

Also during those years: the computer lab at school. *Oregon Trail* was there, but the program that mattered wasn't *Oregon Trail*. It was a conversational one: you could type to it, and it would respond. Insult it and it would tell you to go fly a kite. Be kind to it and it would be kind back. A machine with personality. I couldn't stop thinking about it. It made visible something I had been trying to articulate without success: a world that responded to what you put into it. An intelligence (simulated, artificial, but consistent and responsive) that you could build a relationship with. I thought about it long after I walked out of that computer lab.



At twelve and thirteen I found MUDs (Multi-User Dungeons), text-based online worlds accessible through Telnet at the library. Legends of Merlin. Pandora's Box. My favorite: Rapture of Oblivion, which I still think had the best builder community of any of them.

At fourteen, the admins of one of those servers invited me to build. I lied about my age to get in, easier to do in those days. The tools were online: you'd create a room, write its description, populate it with mobs, script their behavior, set triggers and flags. A cursed item needed its flag. A weapon needed its damage range. A mob needed to know what it said when it aggro'd and what it dropped when it died. I built obsessively. They saw what I was producing and invited me to go further: to actually code.

That meant SSH, a Putty client, compiling changes, submitting for review. The server owner would accept or reject and tell me why; it was the first time anyone had evaluated my work against a standard and explained the gap, and I taught myself all of it because the game was on the other side.

That is where software began for me. Not in a classroom. Not from a mentor with a curriculum. From a text-based world that needed building, and an invitation to come work on it, and the recognition that the tools for getting there were learnable if you wanted them badly enough. I wanted them badly enough.

Dad exploded the situation with Debbie that same year: said something unjustifiable, did something he couldn't walk back, left in the pattern he always followed. I went back to Mom's.



✦ ✦ ✦

At fourteen, my uncle James, Mom's brother, molested me. Single incident. My immediate physical response was to go to the bathroom and vomit. That response (my body's particular way of handling what it cannot metabolize) became a physiological pattern I carried for most of my adult life.

I told Mom, and nothing was done.

This is the real reason I left home at fifteen. Not the general chaos, not the poverty, not the accumulated instability of all of it. The direct cause was being violated and then being failed by the one person who should have protected me. I have not always told it in that order, and I have not always been willing to state the cause that plainly. I am stating it now because this book asks for the parts that are load-bearing, and this is one of them.

✦ ✦ ✦

Sophomore year (Van Buren High School, if you want the official record) I left the house. I did not stop attending school. I crashed on couches: Logan Satterfield, Travis Schmitt, Josh Broadway, whoever would have me for more than a few nights. I slept in my car when it was necessary. When the weather was bad and no couch was available I would sometimes go back to Mom's, but the house was not home and I was clear in my own mind about the difference.

My financial survival ran through The Family Cue Center, a pool hall in Fort Smith owned by a man named Tony. Tony let me brush tables during busy hours in exchange for free table time and paid me twenty dollars a

night to clean up at closing. Twenty dollars was gas and food. I played constantly and got good fast: nothing but time, and something worth putting it into. I fell in love with the game the way I had fallen in love with the MUDs and the library and anything else that rewarded attention and thought and practice with proportional returns.

I still play, and I still play well.



In sophomore English I had a teacher named Mr. Rotert. White hair, short, a little soft in the middle, a deep rich voice that commanded the room when he read. He was kind the way a few teachers are: not generically pleasant, but actually paying attention. He watched me memorize the Marc Antony funeral speech from *Julius Caesar* in a single class period and suggested I enroll in honors and AP.

I did, and my junior year I got straight As in every class.

This was not surprising to me: I had always understood that I could do academic work when I was present enough to do it. What was surprising was that someone looked directly at me and said: you should be in the harder thing. You belong there. Mr. Rotert was not the first person to see me, but he was the first person with institutional standing to act on it, and there is a difference. It mattered more than he knew. It probably mattered more than he ever realized.

Mrs. Davis taught junior and senior English: full of snark and sarcasm, devilishly smart, refusing to protect you from ideas and expecting you to do the same. She died

young, fifteen years or so after I graduated, and I think about her more than she would have expected. She eclipsed even Rotert.

I had art class with a teacher named Mr. Lowe. We did not get along. Once I secured the credit I needed for graduation I stopped attending. I'd stay out shooting pool until two in the morning, sleep, arrive at school by nine for second period. Van Buren eventually kicked me out of the honors and AP program for the absences. I graduated anyway in May 2003, which I considered a reasonable outcome given the circumstances.

♦ ♦ ♦

At fifteen (the same year I left home) I walked into a church and found something I had not known I was looking for.

February 18th, 2001. Some dates you just keep. Whatever the correct theological framing of what happened, what I felt was this: for the first time in my life, I knew what it was to be loved fiercely and unconditionally. My relationship with faith has gotten complicated in the years since, and I'm not going to let that complexity reach backward and hollow out something that was full when it happened.

I became Vice President of Partners in Christ at school. The President was a girl named Sarah Rose Bishop, whom I had known since second grade.

That is a detail I will return to.

Dad was in a meth bender through most of my junior year and returned to Kansas: absent in body, and when present, absent in spirit. Faith filled the structural hole. It gave me a community, a vocabulary for what I was

experiencing, a framework for understanding the chaos I had grown up inside. I went in all the way. I always did, with anything that offered the possibility of comprehension.

Senior year the questions arrived. I found it easier to empathize with Satan than with God: Satan understood failure from the inside, constitutively, whereas an omnipotent perfect God had no frame of reference for it. I said this in Christian community. The community spread rumors that I was worshipping the devil. It was my first round of theological deconstruction, and it was not my last, and I look back on the questions themselves with considerably more respect than I look back on the community's response to them.

✦ ✦ ✦

I graduated in May 2003 knowing three things about myself that I had demonstrated in enough contexts to trust as real and not situational. I could memorize anything and retrieve it on demand: speeches, tests, the encyclopedia volumes I'd worked through in the library, the Marc Antony speech memorized in a single class period. I could build worlds in text: rooms and characters and spells for game servers that real people played in, using tools I had taught myself on machines that didn't belong to me, producing work that was used and valued. And I knew (not in language but in the body) that nothing holds together on its own, that the things worth having have to be built and maintained and defended, that nothing stays without someone deciding it will stay. I had watched enough things fall apart to understand that the falling apart was never an accident. It was always the absence of a decision.



There is a principle at the center of everything I will argue in this book: stability is not the default condition of things. It is designed, or it doesn't exist.

Moving thirty times before you're fifteen teaches you that before it teaches you anything else. Not the lesson itself, not the vocabulary for it, but the instinct underneath it: a watchfulness that develops when nothing around you stays in place. You learn to look for what actually holds versus what merely looks structural. You learn the difference between a wall that is load-bearing and a wall that is decoration, because at some point you have leaned on the wrong one.

The library held. Books held. The pool table held. A screen full of text in a game world nobody could see you playing; that held too, because it responded to what you put into it and it was always there when you came back.

He was my father and I loved him. The knife in the kitchen was also real. I am not telling you that the chaos produced the framework: that would be too clean, too much like a story someone invented to make sense of a life in retrospect. What I am telling you is that the question the framework answers (*how do you build something that survives change?*) was not a question I arrived at from a textbook. I arrived at it from the inside. I had been living inside it since I was six years old and watching my father decide not to die on the kitchen floor.

The rest of this book is the answer I eventually built.

## Chapter 2: December 2nd

2003–2006

\* \* \*

*Life can only be understood backwards; but it must be  
lived forwards.*

(Søren Kierkegaard)

The card declines on a Monday night.

I'm standing in the dining hall at Arkansas Tech University, holding a tray I haven't paid for yet, and the machine says no: not a thirty-dollar shortfall that clears after payday, but empty, something reached in and scooped it clean. I know what happened before I put the card back in my wallet: my roommate Alex had borrowed against it (the meal card, drained by the end of the semester), and I'd been

drunk most of that semester and couldn't give you an accurate accounting of when or how much, and neither of us had been watching the number. What gets me standing there in the fluorescent light isn't the money, exactly (the money is almost beside the point); it's the particular quality of the moment, the realization that the structure I had assembled around myself had a hole in it I hadn't inspected. I had worked to get into this place and done the academic work when I was present enough to do it, but I hadn't been present enough, not in the ways a university requires: not on academic probation yet, but I could see it from where I was standing, the gap between good test scores and poor attendance, and I knew what that trajectory looked like.

December 1st, 2003. I am eighteen years old.

The next morning (December 2nd) my friend Chris Angel finds me and tells me the drop window is still open: if I go to the registrar today, I can preserve the transcript, keep the record clean enough to come back later. He offers to walk me there himself.

I go back to the room and pack everything I own into the Ford Escort hatchback in the lot. I have never owned enough to make packing slow. I am going to New York. I am going to write a novel called *Winds of Change*.

I drive back to Dyer, and on the way I get pulled over for no insurance, which is how New York stops being where I am going. I leave approximately forty library books checked out at Arkansas Tech, along with whatever fines had accumulated (I am not entirely certain I ever paid those), and I would like to tell you I had a plan beyond the novel, but I did not.



The novel does not get written, and what I have instead is a bed at Bubba and Gina's: a trailer in Dyer, five miles from nothing. Richard Dale Harris Jr. is my cousin; Gina is his wife. Neither of them is more than a few years older than me, and Gina has been close with my sisters since before I was paying attention. I had lived with them the summer before ATU, and the warmth in that trailer is genuine and unsurprised. I eat everything in reach. I always have: hollow legs, my mother used to say, and she was right about that if not much else at the time. There is real love in that trailer. For a while we are a sweet, unconventional little family, the three of us, and I did not know then how much I needed that, or how rarely I had had it.

Some of that went back further than the trailer. Bubba had been a fixed point in the story I told about myself long before I showed up on his doorstep with nothing. We rode the same bus out of Flat Rock when I was small, the older kids at the back establishing order the way only cruel and shortsighted children can. In my telling, he was the kind of person who knew exactly where he stood and made that standing visible: someone who moved through the world with an ease I could not locate in myself, who seemed to belong wherever he was without working for it. I remember a kid picking on me and Bubba punching him in the nose. I filed it away as proof of the story I was already telling, and the mythology around him held for twenty years.

The real version is smaller: he and his friends teased me too, picked on me the way older kids tend to do with the one who follows them around, not cruel but not gentle either. I followed them anyway. Not the figure from the bus.



Just a kid, probably carrying his own version of whatever I was carrying and better at not showing it: the coolest person I had ever seen, a sort of hero to the little boy I was. In those years he was still himself, and that was enough. Addiction found him four or five years after this. He broke his ankle. A doctor prescribed Lorcets, which is what doctors did then; the dangers of opiates were not yet the understood thing they would become. Circumstance and genetic predisposition did the rest. He did not want to be an addict. He did not choose it. That is the part I think about: not the ending, but how ordinary the beginning was, how little agency any of it required from him. It did not consume him all at once. That is not what addiction does. It eats away at you from the inside, a kind of spiritual and psychological cancer: slow enough that you can almost not notice it until you cannot miss it anymore. Almost twenty years on, his family would collapse. Last I heard, he was somewhere in Texas.

Dyer in winter is exactly what it sounds like: nothing open, nothing happening, the highway running through without stopping. There is a truck stop diner on that highway, open twenty-four hours, and I pick up night shifts when they are short a body. You learn the regular customers fast: which truckers want coffee kept full without being asked, which ones want to talk at two in the morning and which ones don't, which ones tip and which ones are going to leave you three percent and feel righteous about it. The work is not complicated but it has a cadence, and I go home smelling like grease and coffee with enough to eat and not much more.

When I am not working I am on the Xbox (*Knights of the Old Republic*, which I play for hours at a stretch because the world it builds is coherent and mine is not) or at Midland Bowl for karaoke, where I go up exactly twice after enough ill-gotten beer has quieted the part of me that monitors every syllable before it leaves my mouth. The room will hold you if you go up like you mean it, and I find that to be true of more situations than karaoke.

Mostly I read: the Van Buren public library, twenty minutes up 64 Highway, whatever is in the trailer, Bubba's comic books (Superman, mostly), which is how I first encountered my favorite fictional character. Not because of what he can do. Because of what he chooses not to do. A being with the power to end anything, who decides instead to hold the line. What I am actually reading for is the sensation of being inside a world with rules that hold, a place where if you understand enough of the logic, events stop being arbitrary. I have been trying to find that sensation in the actual world for most of my life, and the books are faster.



In the summer of 2004, Sarah Bishop comes back into my life: the same Sarah who was President of Partners in Christ at Van Buren High while I was Vice President, the same girl I had known since second grade. The year before, her parents had divorced: her father Don was a Southern Baptist preacher, her pastor her entire life, the man who stood at the front of a church every Sunday and talked

about grace and permanence, and now he was in Michigan. She was at her mom's new place, still sorting out what that meant.

We spent two months getting to know each other properly: neither of us in a hurry, both with more to say than we usually had occasion to say. The poetry was serious: our own work, not assigned, not performed for an audience, just things we wrote and handed over and the other person read, which is its own kind of trust. We talked about *The Lord of the Rings* like it mattered, which it did: not the movies, the books, the actual architecture of the world Tolkien built and what it meant that he had built it with such completeness. We put Counting Crows on and didn't say anything at all. We were both learning guitar, which is where the similarity ended: she had rhythm and could carry a tune, things I have not been blessed with, and I teased her about being better at it and she teased me right back.

She is serious and thoughtful in a way that does not announce itself, and I found myself in those months doing something I had rarely done with another person: not performing, not managing the impression I was making, actually thinking about things and then saying what I actually thought and waiting to see what she said back. That is a rarer experience than it sounds. I was nineteen and she was the first person I had met who made it feel normal.

I came close to falling in love with her, and the only thing missing was reciprocity. She still doesn't agree we dated, and I have made peace with this: you carry the standard someone like that sets, and I still do.



Early 2005, the phone rings and it is Grandma Lucas.

Grandma Lucas is my dad's mother. Before I was ten she was just the grandmother in Kansas: the one who took us to Worlds of Fun and bought things and kept a comfortable distance. She wasn't rich; she just had more than we did, which at the time felt like the same thing. On my mom's side was Grandma Harris, Mary Ruth, who never took much interest in us kids, and Grandma Lucas was different from that, but the difference took time. It started when I was ten, and I had spent three or four summers with her between ages ten and fourteen: summers that felt categorically different from everything else in my life. A house in Kansas where the lights stayed on and dinner appeared at the same time every night. A woman with a master's degree in psychiatric nursing and two or three packs of Virginia Slims per day who sat across from me and asked real questions and listened to real answers. The best smoker's laugh I have ever heard: a laugh that costs something and is worth it. She had bought me my first Nikes from a mail-order catalog when I was ten (you circled what you wanted and it arrived at the door six to eight weeks later), and I felt like hot shit. My mother had reported \$9,800 in income for a family of five that year.

What she was doing was seeing me: the brightness and the sadness both, held in the same gaze and loved for what they were. Not the capable public face I had been constructing since I was six, but the whole thing. She loved big: a fixed point, a coordinate established, a distance from which everything else could be measured.

She says: come to Kansas. She will help me get back into college: financial aid, community college, a place to stay while I figure out the next step. She has been doing this since I was ten, finding the next step for me, clearing enough ground that I could see it. More plan than I have had in over a year. More plan, honestly, than I deserve.

I go.

\* \* \*

Kansas means TIG welding at a company called Heatron (I had taken welding as my shop class in high school, which turned out to be transferable): precision heating elements that go into laboratory equipment and industrial machines, things that have to get hot in exactly the right place at exactly the right temperature. I learn to read a weld, to feel when the current is right, to understand in a way that goes past cognition into reflex what the metal wants to do and how to make it do what you need instead. My hands are useful and the day ends with evidence of it.

September 2005, Texas Hold'em at a local VFW hall: I am good at poker for the same reasons I have been good at every game that rewards attention and the reading of other people, and I sit down at the table expecting a comfortable evening. Her name is Avalon, she is seventeen and I am twenty, and we are both kids with more history than we know how to carry and neither of us has the tools to say so. I fall in love completely, without prior reference, without anything to calibrate against; I have been drawn to people before, but this is different, the first time the word actually fits.



November 2005. Grandma Lucas has a stroke.

The college plan does not survive contact with this fact, not because she collapses, but because the capacity that had been underwriting the plan is suddenly occupied with something else entirely: survival, recovery, the long slow work of what comes after a stroke when you are a woman in your sixties who has smoked two or three packs a day for forty years.

With the scaffold gone, I start taking stock of what else exists (what structure is available to a twenty-year-old in Kansas with a welding certificate and no fixed point), and the military comes back as the most legible option on the table. I walk into a recruiting office.

I take the ASVAB and ace it; the recruiter is visibly excited, tells me I can do any job in the military, and I believe him because the score is the most unambiguous thing anyone has shown me in months. I sit across from him and think carefully about what I am and am not willing to do. Nuclear, biological, chemical warfare involves the possibility of pushing a button that ends a lot of lives at once, and I decide no: not because the button would ever be in front of me, but because the role is built around that possibility, and I cannot align myself with it while rejecting what it is built around. Public Affairs is different: you tell the story of what the Marines are doing and why, words and images rather than ordnance, and I understand this role immediately, not as something learned but as something recognized. In January 2006, twenty years old, I ship to boot camp.

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Boot camp is the first institution that has ever asked me to prove what I could do with my body, and my body responds by doing things I did not know it could do: distance runs in the dark, in formation, calling cadence until you become the cadence, until you stop hearing it as words and it becomes rhythm, becomes the sound of your own feet on the ground. The obstacle courses. The swimming. The physical training at hours of the morning that feel less like hours and more like a different country. My hands are rough inside two weeks in a way they have never been, and I lose fifteen pounds and then stop losing weight because there is no more to lose that doesn't come from somewhere essential.

I am named platoon scribe: the recruit who maintains the platoon's official records and correspondence, which means I write and keep track and make sure the paperwork is right. In retrospect, a perfect role: it uses what I have. I also memorize knowledge so that other recruits can recite it (Marine Corps history, chain of command, general orders, the Rifleman's Creed), going through it until it is down to the substrate, below thought, until the words come without the experience of retrieving them. Then I give it to whoever needs it. Not generosity, exactly: if they fail, we fail, and I have spent too much of my life watching preventable failure from the inside.

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February 2006. Grandma Lucas dies.

I am not with her. I did not say goodbye.

This is the sentence I have lived with for twenty years. I was in boot camp, which means I was exactly where I was supposed to be, which means I have absolutely no grounds for guilt in any rational accounting of the situation, and none of that matters at all. She died and I was not there and I did not say goodbye and I was told at morning formation by a staff sergeant whose face, before he said a word, told me something had actually happened.

I leave my platoon and go home, and I stand up at her funeral and say what I had said to someone once, when they asked what she was like: *she saw me, the real me, the brightness and the sadness, and she loved me big*. That is what I say at her funeral. I don't know if I say anything else. I know I meant that.

Then I go back.

♦ ♦ ♦

During range week at Camp Pendleton there is a conflict with a DI; the details feel important at twenty and less so at forty, but the shape of it is familiar: you were right about the principle and wrong about how you handled it, which is the most expensive way to be right. The outcome is Intensive Training, which means a seventy-pound dog target fifty yards away, drop to push-ups, back up, retrieve the target, and repeat until someone says stop.

I do it, and on the third or fourth repetition something tears: deep in the groin, a tearing that goes past pain into something that lives below pain, something your body reports in a more primitive register. I hit my knees, I vomit, and I come close enough to blacking out that the afternoon goes gray at the edges.



That evening at mess, I cannot sound off. My voice is there but something in my lower body is not cooperating with the act of standing at attention and producing volume, and Staff Sergeant Rodriguez comes to me with a look that is patient and skeptical in equal measure: he has seen this before.

"This recruit reports," I say, "that he may have been injured."

He pulls me out, the Navy medic does the assessment and says, with the bluntness that military medicine is built on: *Dude, that is the worst hernia I have ever seen.* The swelling is approximately the size of a grapefruit. I have been carrying it through mess, through the evening routine, through everything after the range, trying to determine whether it was real enough to report. It was real enough to report. They take me in for surgery the next morning.

\* \* \*

The surgery goes well, in the sense that the hernia is repaired. Then a piece of gauze is left at the surgical site, then I develop sepsis, then there is a second surgery to find the gauze and address the infection that has been building since the first one.

A broken recruit: this is a technical status as much as a descriptive one, a recruit who cannot complete training due to injury, held in medical while the body does what it needs to do. There is a ward with a tiny library adjoining it, and there is the debit card they gave me when I enlisted, which accesses my pay and works at the commissary; the government will outfit you with everything strictly required for basic training, and for everything else you buy

it yourself. Snacks are not strictly required for basic training. Snacks are, however, something considerable when you have been living on mess hall food for months.

I read everything in the library and then read it again, and I lie in the ward and think about what I am doing with my life, which is a thought that arrives with particular force when you are twenty years old and your body has failed you through no fault of your own and the woman who saw you clearly is dead and you did not say goodbye and you are approximately two months away from being healthy enough to return to where you started.

My grandmother is dead, my body has failed me, and the depression settles in: not dramatic, not announcing itself, coming in through a back door and rearranging the furniture. You stop noticing things that used to interest you. The days are long. The ward has a specific smell (antiseptic and old air and something beneath both), and the light through the window is the same quality every day, which after a while stops feeling like consistency and starts feeling like nothing. You eat the snacks and you read the library again and you wait.

There is a moment in one of those weeks where I start a letter to Grandma Lucas and then stop, and then sit there for a long time not writing. I know she is dead and I know the letter will not be sent, and I do not throw it away. I don't know what I do with it. I think I might have just kept writing in my head, for a while: I had been talking to her for most of a decade and the habit did not immediately stop.

The question arrives: discharge, or recovery platoon. Recovery platoon means months of reconditioning, returning to training status, eventually being slotted back

into a new platoon at approximately the point in the curriculum where you left. Discharge means leaving. The discharge is medical (neither honorable nor dishonorable, just the category that applies when the body gives out and there's nothing else to call it), but it means going.

I take the discharge.

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I am twenty years old in June 2006, freshly discharged from the Marine Corps, and I have no car (I came to Kansas without one and the person who might have lent me something is gone), so I walk everywhere for the next year or so. Grandma Lucas is dead. The woman I am in love with is in Kansas. The novel is not written.

What I have is the habit of reading, a body that has been through something and survived it, and the beginning of a question I don't yet know how to finish.

Three things failed in four months: Grandma Lucas's stroke, which took the scaffold. Grandma Lucas's death, which closed the door. The injury and its aftermath, which removed the fallback. None of these failures was my fault. All of them were real.

I had assembled something (not quite a plan, but a direction, with a sense of what would hold it up), and I had been wrong about what was actually holding it up. I had been treating her presence as a given when it was a gift. She had made a decision, sustained across four years of Kansas summers, to be a fixed point for a boy who did not have many, and when her body failed, that decision did not automatically survive her. It had been her energy, her continuous investment. It was her.

I did not have language for this yet. What I had was the weight of it: three things I had assumed were solid, gone inside four months, and the recognition that I had been wrong about which of them was actually load-bearing, and that being wrong had cost me, and that I did not know how to stop being wrong in the same way again.

I am going to spend twenty years finding out.

## Chapter 3: The Classifieds

2006–2009

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*Life for me ain't been no crystal stair.*

(Langston Hughes, "Mother to Son")

The man comes in off the street on a Tuesday afternoon (or maybe a Wednesday, the days have the same texture in Overland Park in 2007), and he is in the grip of something, and what he does to the bathroom at Burger King in Overland Park, Kansas, is not something I am going to describe in detail. I'll say: it is thorough. I'll say: my team looks at it and looks at me and there is a collective decision, made without words, that this one is not happening.

I do not want to clean it either. I look at the bathroom and I feel exactly what they feel.

I clean it anyway: some combination of the math being simple (someone has to, and I am the one willing to) and the particular stubbornness that has been getting me into and out of things since I was six years old. The bathroom gets cleaned. I walk out, take off the gloves, and go directly to the newspaper: the actual newspaper classifieds, because it is 2007 and that is how this works.

I am looking for the listing with the highest starting salary for the least required experience. That is the only criterion I have. I am twenty-one years old and I have been cleaning bathrooms and flipping burgers and waiting tables for the better part of a year and I am not interested in doing it for another year. I want the number. I want the biggest number adjacent to the least barrier, and what comes back is software engineering.

A company called Centriq will train candidates in C#, SQL, HTML, and CSS over six months and place them in entry-level developer roles. The ad is direct about what it is: a boot camp for overlooked people, a pipeline into an industry that has not historically cared about credentials as long as you can produce. You take an aptitude test. If you pass, you start.

I leave after my shift, go to the facility, take the test, and sign up before I drive home.

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There is a year before the bathroom.

Kansas, June 2006. I am back from the Marines with a medical discharge and a hernia repair that has mostly healed and a small scar where the gauze was, which is the souvenir the second surgery left. Avalon is there. The plan for college is gone: Grandma Lucas is gone, the scaffold is gone, the fixed point is gone. What is there instead is a city I do not particularly know and a woman I love and the practical question of how to live.

The first apartment is above Tampico's, a Mexican restaurant in a neat stretch of downtown: a little theater on one side, a small indoor mall on the other, the kind of block that has actual foot traffic and feels like a place. The apartment is two bedrooms, one bath, a galley kitchen just wide enough to work in. I love it. The rent is manageable. Two months in, Avalon accidentally (I use that word as she would have used it, with the weight it carries) overdrafts our shared account. The overdraft cascades: one fee triggers the next, then the next, until the account is negative by more than either of us has coming in. I cannot make rent.

There is no version of this where I stay with the account gone and the rent unpayable, so I drive back to Arkansas and give it a few weeks while the math sorts itself out. Then Avalon calls and says she misses me, and I drive back.

The new apartment: \$250 a month, no private bathroom. The toilet and tub are shared, down the hall. There is no shower: if you want to bathe, you sit in the tub. The apartment is fully furnished, utilities included, and it is a slum. The furniture is from some earlier decade and has the smell of having absorbed everything that happened in

it, and the walls are thin because the insulation gave up in some earlier decade. It is not a place you live in. It is a place you survive in, briefly, on your way to the next thing.

The next-door neighbor is Paul. Paul is schizophrenic. Most nights are fine: I have lived around mental illness my whole life and I know how to read the register of a building, know when things are okay and when they are not. But some nights Paul laughs and cries simultaneously, in the same breath, a sound that is not quite either one of the things it contains. An eerie sound. The sound of something trying to be two things at once and not managing to be either. I have never fully shaken it. I hear it sometimes in quiet: not as a memory exactly, more as a frequency I learned to recognize and cannot unlearn.



I sold Kirby vacuums, and I was good at it. I had what the job required: I could read a room, I could build rapport in the first thirty seconds, I could find the thing that mattered to the person across from me and speak to that thing rather than reciting a script. Moderate success. Not enough to get out of the \$250-a-month apartment, but enough to eat and keep the lights on and feel like a person with a skill rather than a person without options.

Then they moved me to a DPS role: recruiting salespeople, training them on the product and the process, sending them home for the weekend to sell to their friends and family. The DPS role required me to teach other people how to do the thing I had learned to do, which meant I had to understand it well enough to explain it, which meant I had to break it into components and sequence them and



figure out which pieces were load-bearing and which ones were style. I was twenty-one years old. I had no framework for what I was doing. I was just doing it.

I think about that role when I am designing onboarding for a new team, when I am trying to figure out how to transfer the thing I know to someone who does not yet know it. The sequence matters. The order in which you introduce components determines whether they make sense when they arrive, or whether they arrive as noise. I learned that selling Kirby vacuums at twenty-one. I have applied it in every job I have had since.

♦ ♦ ♦

August 2006. Avalon tells me she is pregnant.

I tell her it is her choice. I tell her also (because she asks me, directly, and I am not capable of lying about this) that I want the child and that I cannot stay if she terminates: a statement of what I know about myself, offered as clearly as I can offer it. She does not take it as a threat. She knows me well enough to understand the difference.

She says she has gone through with it. She says this about a month after we have the conversation.

We break up.

About a month after that (a fall afternoon, a door) there is a necklace hanging on the handle and an envelope slipped underneath. The necklace is small and careful. The letter is honest: more honest than most things she ever gave me. She was scared. She had not gone through with it. She had told me she had because she was scared of what the conversation would cost and could not face it directly, and

now she was telling me the truth because she could not hold the lie. She was scared of losing me. She was carrying our child.

We reconcile. Her parents visit: they drive in from wherever they were, they see the apartment, they see the bathroom down the hall and the furniture from a decade I wasn't alive for, and they are mortified with the specific, controlled mortification of parents who have raised a daughter to expect better than this and are now confronted with the evidence that she has chosen something else. They help us into a better place. Not a good place: a better one, which is its own category.

I do not resent them for the mortification. They were right. The apartment was not a place to raise a child. We needed the better place.

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April 27th, 2007. University of Kansas Hospital.

Avalon is beautiful and scared. No epidural: everything moves too fast, the labor is not long enough for the timing to work, and then it is too far along, and then it is done. I watch her go through something I cannot help with and can only witness, which is its own kind of experience: to be present for the most significant moment in another person's life and to have no role in it except to be present, to be there, to not leave.

Then the nurse hands him to me.

I have heard people say that the moment you hold your child for the first time is unlike anything else. I had filed that in the category of things people say because the vocabulary for what they mean does not exist in standard

issue language. And then I am holding William Fox Anderson, who is twenty minutes old and weighs slightly more than I expected, and I understand that the people were not exaggerating. They were reporting accurately from the other side of an experience for which the vocabulary genuinely does not exist.

I am twenty-one years old. I have never felt more love than this and I have never felt more unequipped for anything than this and both of those things are absolutely true at the same time. Fox opens his eyes and looks at the light and does not yet know what any of it is and I know (not as a resolution but as a fact, the way facts present themselves when there is no possibility of arguing with them) that I am going to figure this out. I do not know how. I know I am.

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The bathroom at Burger King comes three months before this.

The sequencing matters: I find software engineering before Fox arrives, but only because I can already see what is coming. Avalon is six, maybe seven months along. I know what the child will need, and I know what cleaning bathrooms provides, and the mathematics of those two things do not resolve in any direction that includes the future he deserves. So I go to the classifieds, and the criterion is the same one it has always been (the highest starting salary adjacent to the least required experience), and this time I know exactly what I am looking for it for.

Six months of training: C# and object-oriented programming, SQL and relational databases, HTML and CSS for the front end. The fundamentals, taught fast, taught practically, taught by people who know that everyone in the room came from somewhere else and is trying to get somewhere different and does not have the luxury of learning slowly. I am good at it immediately in the way I was good at the MUDs: the logic of it is not foreign, the idea that you write instructions and the machine follows them, that precision in the writing produces predictable behavior in the result. I had understood that at fourteen on an SSH client at the public library. Now I was learning to call it by its right names.

The thing about learning a formal discipline when you already have the instinct is that the vocabulary arrives and illuminates what was already there. Object-oriented programming gave me the language for something I had been doing in the MUD room builders: the idea that you define a thing's properties and behaviors together, that a mob is not just a set of stats but an entity with state and rules for how that state changes. SQL gave me the language for the questions I had been asking in every job before it: how do you describe what you need in a way that the system can answer precisely? The names mattered. Not because the instinct was wrong before the names, but because the names let you communicate the instinct to other people, which is the difference between a skill you can use and a skill you can teach.

I completed the program. I was not the most technically polished in my cohort: not the one who had been programming since high school in the formal sense, not the

one whose code was the cleanest. What I was, was the one most willing to ask why. Not to challenge the instructors, not to show what I already knew, but because I genuinely wanted to understand what the thing was actually for. The instructors noticed. I was placed.

♦ ♦ ♦

The first job came through a Kansas state work program that subsidizes salaries for overlooked candidates (paying half for six months to open the door), and it placed me at Civic Plus in Manhattan, Kansas, building digital government solutions: websites and portals for municipalities and counties, the digital layer of local government. The rate was twenty dollars an hour. My mother had reported \$9,800 in income for a family of five during my senior year of high school. I am twenty-two years old, and twenty dollars an hour is a king's ransom: something that was supposed to be behind a locked door, except the door was open and I walked through it.

What made that number significant was not only what it bought, though what it bought was real: food, rent, clothes for Fox, the ability to make a plan that extended further than the current month. What made it significant was what it meant structurally. Every job before it had paid in a register that did not compound (gas station wages, Kirby commissions, burger-flipping pay); each of those covered the present moment and nothing beyond it, and you could work hard and cover the present moment harder, but hard work in those registers does not produce a different future. It produces a slightly more survivable present.

Twenty dollars an hour produced a different register entirely, and I knew it: the possibility of compounding, of savings, of skill development, of a career rather than a succession of jobs. I had gotten there through one aptitude test and six months of training and the luck of an industry that was hiring people it wouldn't have hired in any other decade (I knew how much of it was luck, knew how much the luck had depended on one specific decision, walking out of a burger franchise bathroom and opening a newspaper), and I did not take any of it for granted. I worked harder than I had worked at anything.

♦ ♦ ♦

Civic Plus opens the next door: the Kansas Department of Transportation, and Geographic Information Systems (GIS applications, the software layer on top of spatial data, maps and road networks and the infrastructure information that keeps a state's transportation system legible to the people who manage it). I am learning, as fast as I can learn, not just the tools but the domain: what the software has to do, who uses it and what they need, the gap between what the current systems provide and what would actually be useful. I am twenty-two years old and already instinctively asking the question that will define my career: not *how do I build this* but *what problem does this actually solve, and for whom?*

The Kansas Department of Transportation leads to DISC: the Department of Information Systems and Communications, the central IT hub for Kansas state government. I am building legislative tracking tools for both chambers: bill progress, participation monitoring, anticipated voting patterns. Real systems with real users

who have real needs and real frustrations with what they currently have. The work is not glamorous in the startup sense. It is exacting and detailed and the margin for error is low because the systems I am building are used by people whose work matters. I find this more interesting than glamour. It has the quality the welding had: there is a standard, and the standard is clear, and meeting it requires something real from you.

The legislative tracking work is where I first encounter a problem I will spend twenty years working on: the gap between what users say they need and what they actually need. Legislators and their staff tell me what they want the system to do. I build exactly that. Then they use it and discover that what they said and what they meant were not the same thing: that the need they described was the surface, and the need underneath it was different, and the only way to find the one underneath was to put something in front of them and watch what they did with it.

The frustration of this, early on, is real: you do the work, you do it correctly, and then the work turns out to have solved the wrong problem.

Later I will understand this as a feature of requirements, not a failure of communication. The need does not always know itself. Users are experts in their domain, not in software: they describe what they experience, not what would resolve it. The job is to hear what is said and also hear what is underneath it, to build toward the real problem even when the stated problem is pointing somewhere else. I do not have the vocabulary for this yet in 2007 and 2008. But I am beginning, encounter by encounter, to develop the instinct.

I am learning what I will spend twenty years learning: that the quality of software is determined almost entirely by the quality of the questions asked before a line of code is written. Not what can I build, but what needs to exist and why and for whom and what happens when it changes. The framework is not there yet. The instinct is there, accumulating: not in theory but in contact with real problems in real systems for real people who need the thing to work.

✦ ✦ ✦

Through all of this, Avalon and I are fraying; she is the mother of my son and she is not here to tell her side of it, and her side of it is real.

I am working hard. I am learning fast. I am building: professionally, financially, in every direction I know how to build. And I am doing this at twenty-two, twenty-three years old, with a child who is growing fast and a relationship that has been under strain since the \$250-a-month apartment, since the shared bathroom, since the pregnancy and the reconciliation and the hospital room and the weight of everything that arrived at once in the year Fox was born.

She is struggling with the adjustment to motherhood in ways I cannot fully see because I am not home enough to see them, and because when I am home I do not have as much grace as I could have. That last sentence costs me something to write, because it is the simplest and most honest account of what happened, and simplicity in honest accounting does not erase complexity; it just locates the weight correctly. I was building the right things for the



wrong reasons in some proportion I have never been able to calculate precisely. The right reasons: Fox needed a different life than the one I'd had. The wrong reasons: I was building to prove something to myself, to the gap between what I had been and what I needed to become, and that kind of building does not leave much room for another person's experience.

She deserved more grace. I did not have more to give at the time. I have spent the years since then learning to have more.

♦ ♦ ♦

April 2009. Fox is two years old: twenty-three months, more precisely, because at that age the months are the right unit.

I leave Kansas with Fox and a broken relationship behind me. The relationship is not repaired before I leave. It may not have been repairable. What I know is that I leave with the child, that Fox comes with me, and that the direction I am pointed is Arkansas: back to where I started, with everything I have learned in three years, with a two-year-old in the back seat and a career that is just barely beginning to compound.

♦ ♦ ♦

There is a principle in Harmonic Design that I call volatility-based decomposition: the idea that you should design your systems around what changes, not around what currently is. The designs that fail are almost always designs built around the current state of things: optimized for the problem as it exists today, brittle in the presence of everything that happens next. The designs that hold are

built with the question already embedded: what is going to change here, and have I designed for that change, or have I designed as though change won't happen?

I did not have that in language in 2006. Not in 2007 or 2008 or 2009. What I had was the experience of watching things fail (my parents', Bubba's, Grandma Lucas's, mine) and the instinct, built up over twenty years of living inside failure, that the question underneath all of it was the same one. Not *why did this fail* but *what was I assuming would hold that didn't?*

The bathroom at Burger King was a volatility event in miniature: something unexpected happened, the existing system (my coworkers, the status quo, the implicit agreement about how things worked) was not designed to absorb it, and what remained was a choice. Accept things as they were, or step outside them and ask the next question.

Every door I walked through in those three years came from that question. Centriq came from it. Civic Plus came from it. The state of Kansas came from it. Not because I had a plan. I did not have a plan, not in the sense of a document or a clear destination. What I had was the reflex, the instinct, the capacity to look at a situation and ask: is this load-bearing, or does it just look load-bearing? What is actually holding this up?

The answer was almost never what it appeared to be.

✦ ✦ ✦

I drove out of Kansas in April 2009 with Fox asleep in his car seat and a career that had started in a six-month training program and grown, in three years, into something that could compound: a skill, a rate, the beginnings of a

reputation that was small and local and didn't travel, but real. And a two-year-old who was going to need everything I could build for the next sixteen years.

I had, without knowing I had it, the question that would organize the next two decades: not what is the right answer, but what is the right question? Not how do I build this, but what is this actually for, and what is going to change, and have I built for the change or against it?

The framework was not invented yet. It was not close to being invented. What was there was the instinct (the particular quality of attention that develops when you grow up inside instability): moves, broken things, a sequence of situations that turned out not to hold. You learn to look for the load-bearing element. You learn to find it, name it, and build around it rather than around what looks solid from the outside.

The rest (the framework, the vocabulary, the twenty years of practice at scale): that is the work of the chapters that follow.

But it started here. In a bathroom in Overland Park, Kansas. With a mop and a newspaper and the simplest possible question: what pays the most for the least barrier, and how fast can I get there?

The question was small. What it opened was not small at all.